

PTI

STRATEGY SESSION PM Narendra Modi and his team leave after a meeting at the Parliament library, Jul. 21

serious scrutiny of what they have delivered. Pradhan's name had figured in reshuffle speculation earlier, and one explanation for his continuance was his proximity to Shah. It does not help that he eventually exited through resignation rather than a broader reorganisation, because it suggests that public pressure forced a change the prime minister would have preferred to make on his own terms. Party sources are expecting the biggest reshuffle of Modi 3.0 to communicate two messages at once: performance matters, and a younger generation is ready to take charge.

The backlog in the Modi cabinet reflects in the organisation as well. A national team for party president Nitin Nabin has been pending for months. The appointment of a 45-year-old national president was read inside the party as the beginning of a handover to a younger generation, and Nabin has said in private conversations that he wants a 50:50 blend of new faces and old hands. That has yet to happen. UP still lacks a full-time in-charge. Punjab has none either. Uttarakhand, one of the nine states without a general secretary (organisation), votes in six months. State leaderships, particularly of Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh and Uttarakhand, are said to be under review as well. The BJP changed CMs in Uttarakhand thrice and won anyway. A change or two would signal that accountability does not stop in Delhi.

EXPERTS SAY A CABINET RESHUFFLE HAS NOW BECOME AN IMPERATIVE FOR PM MODI TO REWARD PERFORMANCE AND TO GIVE CHARGE TO A YOUNGER COHORT

Realigning the bureaucracy is the harder part, as is evident in the current education crisis. Sources in both the BJP and the RSS say that this government leans too heavily on its officers, that the political leadership in several ministries has been reduced to signing off on decisions that have already been made, and that the officers concerned are not held accountable when those decisions go wrong. Over the past decade, serving and retired civil servants have begun presiding over a great deal of the institutional apparatus, be it Sanjay Malhotra at the RBI, Tuhin Kanta Pandey at SEBI, Ajay Seth at IRDAI since September, Ravneet Kaur at the Competition Commission of India and Injeti Srinivas at the NSE. The reforms intended to change this equation have moved slowly. Mission Karmayogi and the lateral entry push delivered far less than was promised.

The result was the political explosion this summer. Modi has repeatedly demonstrated an ability to turn political setbacks into opportunities. He will need that skill once again. But before anything else, he must win back the confidence of the generation that will define India's future. ■

—with Kaushik Deka and M.G. Arun